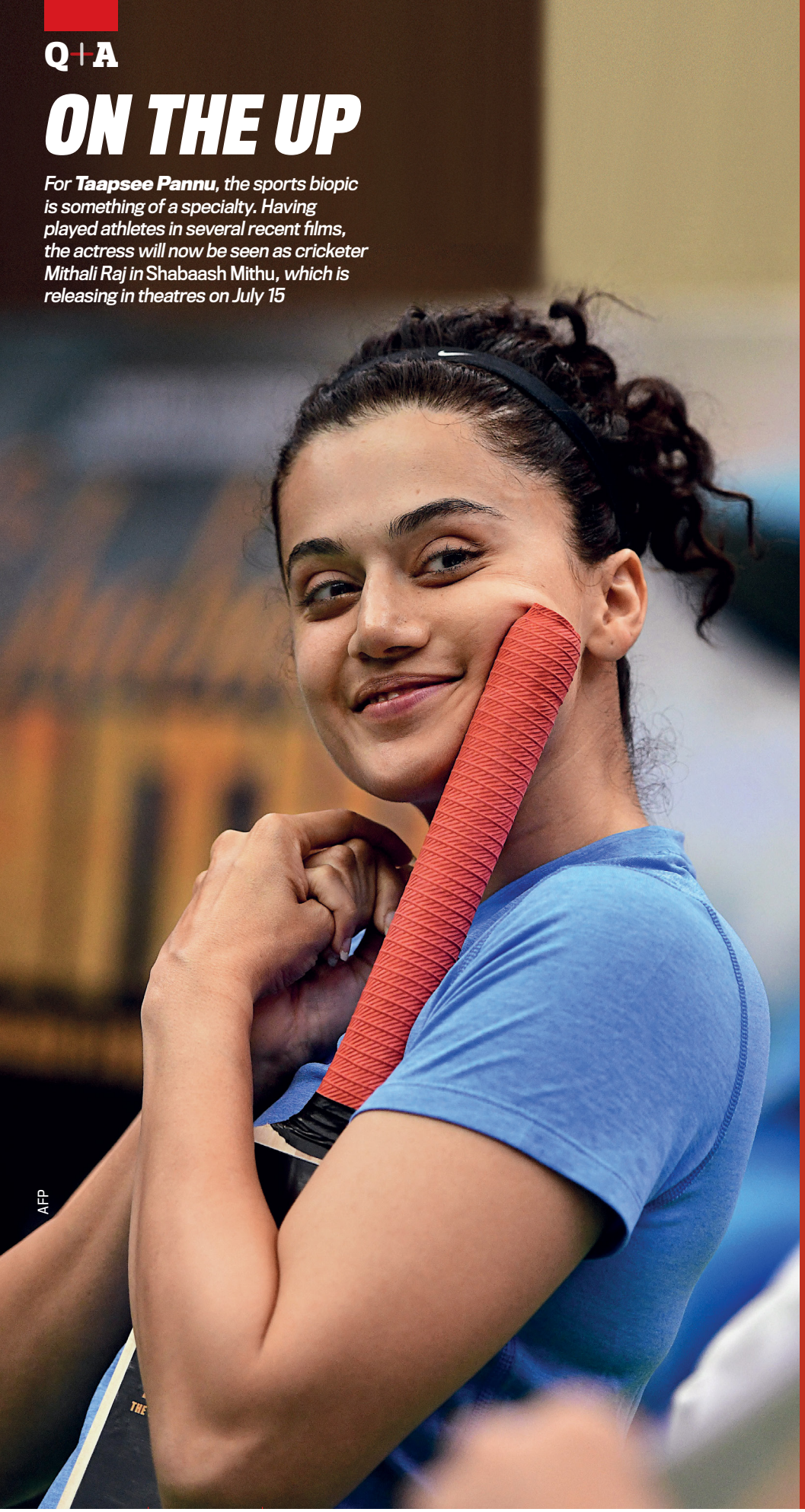
Q+A

ON THE UP

*For **Taapsee Pannu**, the sports biopic is something of a specialty. Having played athletes in several recent films, the actress will now be seen as cricketer Mithali Raj in* Shabaash Mithu, *which is releasing in theatres on July 15*



AFP

Q. Hockey, shooting, running, now cricket...is there any sport left that you still want to play on screen?
I have been asked to play a swimmer, a cyclist, a shot putter, a footballer and a gymnast, too. I kept getting sport stories which were better than the previous film, so I kept doing them. But I am exhausted now. It's time to pause.

Q. Has your partner Mathias Boe [Olympic medallist in badminton doubles and coach] suggested you essay the role of a shuttler?
I don't think he wants me to at all because he'd just be scrutinising. I don't want to be told what to do or what not to do all the time.

Q. How much time did it take you to master Mithali Raj's cover drive?
I started with it. It's the shot I practised the most during my two-hour daily training with Nooshin [al-Khadeer, cricketer]. So much so that even in dreams, my foot would be out and it's the stroke I'd play regardless of where the ball is pitched.

Q. What is the most standout quality of Raj's that you wanted to bring out?
That she is an ardent observer. Unlike me, she is not too expressive. While making this film, I learned how you can celebrate your highest highs and lowest lows by projecting a limited range of emotion. But how do you show 20 years of her life by staying within that narrow range of expressions and make the audience feel what she does? That was a huge challenge.

Q. You recently shared your joy on social media after bagging Rajkumar Hirani's next, *Dunki*, with Shah Rukh Khan....
It is a kind of validation. It is proof that if you consistently work towards what you feel is right and good without getting deterred, then you don't really need recommendations, shortcuts and flukes to get this opportunity.

–with Suhani Singh